

PARENTS' ROLE IN NURTURING ATHLETES

The impulse to engage in play is shared by nearly every child, and this truism is all too banal. The activity of playing has deep evolutionary roots and is the primary means through which children learn about their surroundings and the world in general, thereby preparing them for adulthood. To define the overlap or separation of the categories of playful activity and sports is no simple task. Moreover, one notes with interest that many, if not most, children, particularly boys, seek to emulate a sporting celebrity, though such aspiration often attenuates sooner than later owing to a lack of support or resources.

The primary explanatory variable dictating the success or lack thereof for a child's future sporting career are the parents, through whose agency of moral and financial support, much can be lost! This is no frivolous claim as evinced by Mary Kom's parents, who supported her pursuit of boxing despite social norms, Richard Williams structuring the sporting lives of Serena and Venus Williams, and LeBron James's mother working multiple jobs to support her son, just to name a few. Given this, it is important for parents to take cognizance of their manner of support of their wards that would at best turn out a star athlete and at worst turn out a well-rounded individual

Such support begins with encouraging sporting activities from a young age irrespective of the child's gender and fostering a lifelong love for sports and physical activity while also emphasizing its crucial role for a healthy lifestyle.

Encourage participation in multiple sports for overall development, and prioritise fun over competition until puberty. It is best to avoid imposing a sport upon a child. Rather, allow the child to figure out a sport based on their preference and available resources.

Provide positive reinforcement and constructive feedback. Avoid excessive pressure and comparison as these can lead to burnout and unnecessary stress.

Provide kids with proper training, injury prevention education, nutrition, hydration, adequate sleep and recovery.

Unwavering support throughout the child's sporting journey, through wins and losses, will go a long way in ensuring the wellbeing and the physical and emotional development of the child, thereby cultivating a fertile ground for well-rounded individuals and ace athletes!



***Halt Sports Injuries (HSI) : An Ortho One Initiative to create awareness through learning sessions and provide medical support at subsidised cost for deserving sports persons.
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